

# Topic: Social structure of Colonial Bengal

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# Social structure of colonial Bengal

- 1. British Colonial Administration:** The British East India Company and later the British Crown ruled Bengal during the colonial period. They established a hierarchical administrative system with British officials at the top. Bengal was a part of British India and was governed by a Lieutenant Governor.
- 2. Bengali Aristocracy:** Before British rule, Bengal had a traditional aristocracy composed of zamindars (landlords) and aristocratic families. Many of these aristocrats lost their power and influence as the British introduced the Permanent Settlement Act in 1793, which fixed land revenue rates and often led to the dispossession of landowners. Some zamindars, however, managed to maintain their status and wealth.

# Social structure of colonial Bengal (continue)

**3. Rural Society:** The rural society in Bengal was primarily agrarian. The majority of the population was engaged in agriculture, and the social structure revolved around landownership. Peasants and agricultural laborers formed the bulk of the population. The British land revenue policies had a significant impact on the rural economy and social structure.

**4. Urban Society:** Urban centers like Calcutta (now Kolkata) and Dhaka saw the emergence of a new class of professionals, including lawyers, doctors, and civil servants. The growth of trade and commerce also led to the rise of a merchant class in urban areas. The urban society was more cosmopolitan and diverse compared to rural areas.

# Social structure of colonial Bengal (continue)

**5. Caste System:** The caste system continued to play a significant role in the social structure of colonial Bengal. Hindu society was divided into various castes, with Brahmins at the top and Dalits (formerly known as untouchables) at the bottom. The British introduced laws to address caste-based discrimination and uplift the lower castes.

**6. Religious Diversity:** Bengal was known for its religious diversity, with Hindus, Muslims, Buddhists, and other religious communities coexisting. The majority of the population was Hindu, but there was a significant Muslim minority. The religious composition had an impact on social relations and politics.

# Social structure of colonial Bengal (continue)

**7. Education and Reform Movements:** The colonial period witnessed the emergence of educational institutions and reform movements. Prominent leaders like Raja Ram Mohan Roy and Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar played pivotal roles in advocating for social reforms, including widow remarriage, Satidah protha and women's education.

**8. Political Movements:** Bengal was a center of political activism during the colonial period. The partition of Bengal in 1905 and the subsequent Swadeshi Movement were significant events in the struggle for independence. These movements brought together people from different social backgrounds in the fight against British rule.

# Social structure of colonial Bengal (continue)

**9. Impact of British Policies:** British policies, such as the introduction of modern education and the legal system, had a transformative impact on Bengal's social structure. They facilitated the emergence of a new middle class and contributed to social change.

**10. Women's Role:** Traditional gender roles were prevalent in colonial Bengal, with women primarily confined to domestic duties. However, the period also saw the emergence of women's movements advocating for social and political rights.